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Economy of Egypt

The **economy of Egypt** is a developing, mixed economy, combining private enterprise with centralized economic planning and government regulation.[24] It is the second-largest economy in Africa, and 42nd in worldwide ranking as of 2025. Egypt is a major emerging market economy and a member of the African Union, BRICS, and a signatory to the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA). The country is witnessing a period of economic recovery after facing serious financial challenges.[25]

The Egyptian economy has been bolstered by a series of reforms under its sustainable development strategy Egypt Vision 2030, including a dramatic currency flotation in 2024 that led to a 38% depreciation of Egyptian pound against the dollar after securing over $50 billion in international financing. These actions, alongside strategic agreements with global partners such as the IMF, World Bank, the European Union, and the Gulf States, have contributed to an improved credit outlook.[25]

Since the 2000s, structural reforms (including fiscal and monetary policies, taxation, privatization and new business legislation) helped Egypt move towards a more market-oriented economy and increased foreign investment. The reforms and policies strengthened macroeconomic annual growth results and helped to address the country's serious unemployment and poverty rates.[26][27]

Despite facing significant challenges, especially external shocks such as the global economic impacts of the Ukraine conflict and regional instability, Egypt's economy remains resilient. The government's efforts to engage with international financial markets and stabilize the economy have paved the way for continued growth and further economic integration within the broader African and global markets.[25] The country benefits from political stability; its proximity to Europe, and increased exports.[28]

Economy of Egypt

The business district in Egypt's planned new capital, a flagship project reflecting the country's efforts to attract investment, expand infrastructure, and drive economic growth.

Currency	Egyptian pound (ISO code: EGP, abbreviation: LE)
Fiscal year	1 July – 30 June
Trade organisations	AfCFTA, African Union, COMESA, CAEU, WTO, BRICS
Country group	Developing/emerging[1] ▪ Lower-middle income economy[2]
Statistics	
Population	▲ 109,450,000 (2025)[3]
GDP	▼ $347.34 billion (nominal, 2025)[3] ▲ $2.37 trillion (PPP, 2025)[3]
GDP rank	42nd (nominal; 2025) 17th (PPP; 2025)
GDP growth	▲ 3.8% (2025 est.)[3]
GDP per capita	▼ $3,174 (nominal, 2025 est.)[3] ▲ $21,668 (PPP, 2025 est.)[3]
GDP per capita rank	133rd (nominal; 2025) 87th (PPP; 2025)
GDP by sector	Agriculture: 10.6% Industry: 32.7% Services: 51.6% (2023 est.)[4]
GDP by component	Household consumption: 82.6% Government consumption: 6.8% Investment in fixed capital: 15.2%

History

Ancient Egypt

The economy in ancient Egypt was deeply embedded in its centralized state structure, with the pharaoh exercising theoretical control over all land and resources. Wealth was managed and redistributed through a network of temples and

Rectangular fishpond with ducks and lotus planted round with date palms and fruit trees, Tomb of Nebamun, Thebes, 18th Dynasty

granaries overseen by appointed officials, particularly the vizier, who supervised land surveys, tax collection, and resource allocation. While coinage was not used until the Late Period, Egyptians relied on a barter-based economy, where standardized values, such as sacks of grain and copper deben, were used for wages and trade. Laborers received monthly grain rations, and a fixed price system regulated commerce throughout the kingdom.[29][30]

Agriculture formed the foundation of the economy, sustained by the annual flooding of the Nile, which deposited nutrient-rich silt on the fields. The state taxed agricultural production according to the land owned, and farmers were obligated to provide both goods and labor through a corvée system. Emmer and barley were the primary staples, used to make bread and beer, while flax provided linen for clothing. Papyrus was harvested for writing material, and vegetables such as leeks, garlic, melons, and pulses were cultivated alongside fruits like grapes and dates. Additional goods included textiles, beer, wine, honey, and leather, many of which were produced in temple workshops. Livestock, such as cattle, poultry, donkeys, and bees, played vital economic and ritual roles, while natural resources like copper, gold, alabaster, and granite were extracted through state-controlled expeditions.[31][32][33][34]

Greco-Roman period

A silver coin of 40 drachmai (1 obol) minted in Alexandria between 51 and 30 BC, with Cleopatra VII depicted on the obverse, and an eagle on a thunderbolt with the inscription "ΒΑΣΙΛΙΣΣΗΣ ΚΛΕΟΠΑΤΡΑΣ" (Basilissēs Kleopatras) on the reverse.[35]

	Investment in inventories: -2.3% Exports of goods and services: 19.2% Imports of goods and services: -21.3% (2023 est.)[4]
Inflation (CPI)	20% (2025)[3]
Population below poverty line	▼ Multidimensional poverty: 2% (2021)[5] ▼ At $4.20/day: 7% (2021)[6] ▼ At $8.30/day: 59% (2021)[7] ▼ National poverty line: 29.7% (2019)[8]
Gini coefficient	31.9 medium (2019)[9]
Human Development Index	▲ 0.754 high (2025)[10] (100th) ▲ 0.582 medium IHDI (2025)[10] (98th)
Corruption Perceptions Index	▲ 35 out of 100 points (2023, 108th rank)
Labour force	▲ 33.75 million (2024)[11] ▲ 45.5% participation rate (2024)[12]
Labour force by occupation	Agriculture: 18.66% Industry: 26.36% Services: 52.98% (2022 est.)[13]
Unemployment	▼ 6.3% (Q1 2025)[14] ▼ 18.8% youth unemployment (2024; 15 to 24 year-olds)[15] ▲ 2.445 million unemployed (2024)[16]
Main industries	textiles, food processing, tourism, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, hydrocarbons, construction, cement, metals, light manufactures
External	
Exports	▼ $51.1 billion (2023)[17]
Export goods	Refined petroleum, petroleum gas, nitrogenous fertilizers, crude petroleum and gold.[17]
Main export partners	Saudi Arabia 10.4% Turkey 9.06% Italy 5.68% United States 5.35% United Arab Emirates 4.75%
Imports	▼ $88.2 billion (2023)[17]

Ptolemaic Egypt blended traditional agrarian systems with new fiscal and administrative reforms.[36] The economy produced wheat, flax, wine, and textiles, with state control over beer, oil, and salt. Agriculture, organized around the Nile's flood cycle, remained central.[36] The early Ptolemies implemented extensive land reclamation where immigrant Greeks and military settlers were granted privileged access to land, while native Egyptians were pushed into subordinate roles with limited protections.[36] Greeks also dominated Hellenic urban centers and viticulture, while the administrative spread of the Greek language displaced Demotic, restricting Egyptian access to legal and bureaucratic institutions.[36]

The state developed a complex and unequal tax system on land, produce, labor, and individuals, collected via granaries and banks.[36] Taxation favored Greeks through exemptions and privileges, while Egyptians faced heavier burdens.[36] Temples retained economic significance but lost autonomy under centralized administration.[36] Early Ptolemaic Egypt experienced a notable degree of prosperity, driven by land reclamation, urban expansion, and the growth of fiscal and agricultural systems, though this development was ultimately constrained by institutional rigidity and entrenched social inequality, contributing to later unrest.[36]

During the Greco-Roman and Byzantine periods, Egypt, particularly Upper Egypt, became renowned for its textile production.[37] Workshops across the country produced what came to be known as *Coptic textiles*, characterized by intricate designs, vivid colors, and techniques such as tapestry weaving.[37] These textiles preserved elements of Pharaonic craftsmanship while integrating Greco-Roman stylistic influences.[37] In the Byzantine period, linen and woolen textiles featuring geometric, vegetal, and figural motifs flourished, forming the artistic and technical foundation for Egypt's later Islamic textile industry, which adopted and adapted many of these decorative traditions.[37]

Import goods	Refined petroleum, wheat, petroleum gas, packaged medicaments and cars.[17]
Main import partners	China 16% Saudi Arabia 6.16% Russia 5.62% United States 5.62% Germany 5.38%
FDI stock	▲ $46.07 billion (2024)[18]
Current account	-5.8% of GDP (2025)[3]
Gross external debt	▲$155.2 billion (2024)[19]
Public finances	
Government debt	▼87% of GDP (2025)[3]
Foreign reserves	▲ $48.14 billion (April 2025)[20]
Budget balance	−$41.80 billion (2025)[3]
Revenues	▲$57.63 billion (2025)[3]
Expenses	▲$99.43 billion (2025)[3]
Credit rating	Standard & Poor's:[21] B Outlook: Stable Moody's:[22] B3 Outlook: Stable Fitch:[23] B+ Outlook: Stable
All values, unless otherwise stated, are in US dollars.	

Middle Ages

Beginning in the early Islamic period, Egypt's countryside was incorporated into a broader administrative and fiscal structure that facilitated the movement of goods and surplus to urban centers.[38] By the 11th and 12th centuries, this integration had developed into a dynamic economic relationship between rural producers and commercial networks.[38] Villages produced grain, flax, indigo, sugar, and linen textiles, much of which was sent to Fustat, the primary urban hub for redistribution.[38] Documents from the Cairo Geniza reveal that rural merchants and producers were involved in long-distance trade linking Egypt to the Mediterranean and the Indian Ocean.[38]

The textile industry was a foundational component of Egypt's economy during the Middle Ages, integrating agriculture, manufacturing, and commerce.[39] Flax was widely cultivated, and its transformation into linen textiles constituted a major branch of productive activity.[39] Textile production involved both privately organized enterprise and operations connected to government institutions. In addition to being a leading export commodity, textiles also circulated within the domestic economy as a means of exchange and a store of value.[39] Egypt's prosperity during this period depended not only on its role in international trade but also on the internal scale and organization of its textile production.[39]

A Mamluk-era wool carpet from Egypt, c. 1500–1550.

Patterns of saving and investment during this period reflected a high degree of economic organization.[40] Wealth was accumulated through land, textiles, and monetary holdings, and often reinvested into productive activities such as textile manufacture, agriculture, and trade.[40] The integration of these practices into everyday economic life highlights the structured financial environment that characterized medieval Egypt.[40] In the fifteenth century, Egypt experienced a series of economic and financial crises under the Mamluk regime, marked by inflation, currency instability, and fiscal disorder.[41] Contemporary scholars such as al-Maqrizi and al-Asadi offered detailed assessments of the causes and proposed reforms.[41] Al-Maqrizi identified the debasement of the currency and the overreliance on copper coinage as central problems, advocating a return to the use of gold and silver standards.[41] Al-Asadi presented a broader analysis, attributing the crisis to both monetary mismanagement and deeper structural inequalities, including the concentration of wealth and administrative corruption.[41]

Early modern period

Egypt's earliest industrial efforts began under Muhammad Ali (r. 1805–1849), whose state-led program focused on military goods, agricultural processing, and textiles.[42] By the 1830s, 30 cotton mills employed around 30,000 workers, but the experiment collapsed due to poor management, fuel shortages, and reliance on forced corvée labor.[42] Though short-lived, this phase weakened traditional artisan guilds and introduced wage labor.[42] A later wave under Isma'il Pasha (r. 1863–1879), sparked by the American Civil War cotton boom, saw attempts at diversification with sugar refineries and textile plants.[42] These too struggled against European competition, but they helped expand Egypt's wage labor force and laid foundations for a modern working class.[42]

Between 1869 and 1876, Ismail launched British-led military campaigns against Sudanese slave raiders, as part of broader efforts to reassert Egyptian authority in Sudan.[43] The process culminated in the signing of the Anglo-Egyptian Slave Trade Convention in 1877, which formally ended the practice of slavery and slave trade in Egypt.[43] Ismail's increasing political subordination to Britain, particularly after Egypt's default on its international debt in 1876, likely facilitated the agreement.[43]

By the late 19th century, a clearer working class began to emerge. This was shaped by Egypt's integration into the global capitalist economy under foreign control, especially following the British occupation in 1882.[42] European capital, attracted to Egypt's export sector, invested heavily in transport and utilities, prompting the development of urban infrastructure but neglecting broader industrialization.[42] Employment in these sectors, especially railways, ports, and public utilities, formed the nucleus of the new working class.[42]

Legal reforms under Muhammad Ali and his successors enabled land privatization, displacing a third of the peasantry by the late 19th century.[42] Many had migrated to cities, joining an expanding pool of wage laborers. Meanwhile, the rise of foreign capital eroded Egypt's artisan guilds, particularly after the 1890 Professional Permits Duty.[42] Guilds fractured, with guild heads becoming labor contractors and members reduced to common laborers, leading to tensions culminating in early labor unrest such as the 1882 Port Said coal loaders' strike.[42]

King Fuad I with his ministers on a visit to the phosphate mines in the Red Sea region.

By the early 20th century, guild-based trades had collapsed, leading to a notable increase in wage labor.[42] Foreign skilled workers, mainly Greeks, Armenians, and Italians, introduced European labor ideologies and led early strikes in sectors like cigarettes, tailoring, and printing.[42] However, wage disparities and employer manipulation often hindered unity with Egyptian workers.[42] Strikes in the tram and railway sectors fostered unionization and greater class awareness, especially during the 1908 and 1911 Cairo tram strikes, which drew harsh repression and led to martial law in 1914.[42]

Despite several waves of industrial experimentation, early attempts at industrialization struggled due to factors like tariff restrictions imposed by Britain through the 1838 commercial treaty. In the beginning of the 20th century, little industrial development occurred, and Egypt's land-owning elite invested mainly in land rather than industry.[44] Foreign competition stunted domestic ventures, with only a few enterprises, such as sugar and cotton processing, surviving under foreign ownership.[44] In the following years, over one million Egyptians would be conscripted to the Egyptian Labour Corps and Egyptian Camel Transport Corps to support British efforts in World War I, often through coercion.[42] Simultaneously, wartime shortages fostered growth in domestic industries such as textiles and food processing, prompting the establishment of the Commission of Commerce and Industry in 1916.[42]

Talaat Harb, widely regarded as the father of the modern Egyptian economy[45]

By the 1920s, Egypt’s urban labor force had grown significantly, supported by a limited but increasing domestic industrialization under a wave of economic nationalism[42] pioneered in large part by Talaat Harb, an Egyptian financier. In 1920, Harb founded Banque Misr, the country’s first national bank funded entirely with Egyptian capital, with an initial start-up capital of EGP 80,000 (approximately USD 5,000).[45] Harb envisioned a financial institution that would channel national savings into industrial and economic development.[45] His efforts marked a turning point in Egypt’s economic history, enabling Egyptians to exert greater control over their country’s financial resources and laying the foundation for national industrialization.[45]

Beyond banking, Harb spearheaded the establishment of multiple industrial and service ventures across textiles, insurance, shipping, real estate, and media.[45] He founded Studio Misr in 1935, which became Egypt’s leading film production hub for over three decades, as well as EgyptAir in 1932, the first airline in the Middle East and the seventh in the world.[45] Through Banque Misr, he also launched companies in cotton ginning, paper manufacturing, and printing, helping to create a vertically integrated national economy. These initiatives were critical in asserting Egypt’s economic independence and identity during and after the colonial period.[45]

The Great Depression helped catalyze industrialization, shifting Egypt toward import-substitution industries.[44] In 1930, the expiration of commercial treaties allowed Egypt to control its tariff policies, fostering local industry.[46] On February 16, 1930, Egypt enacted tariff reforms aimed at protecting local industries. The government imposed high duties on imports and reduced taxes on raw materials, encouraging local manufacturing. The changes led to a decline in imports of finished goods and an increase in raw materials and machinery by 1938.[47]

World War II provided a boost to industrialization, with increased demand from Allied forces and local consumers. Many industries diversified, while new enterprises emerged.[48] The war also trained workers, helping to establish a foundation for local industries that expanded in the post-war period. By 1947, the government enacted laws and established an industrial bank to support industrial growth.[48]

Early Republican period

In July 1952, the Egyptian monarchy was overthrown in a coup led by the Free Officers movement, a group of army officers founded by Gamal Abdel Nasser and formally headed by General Muhammad Naguib. The officers held King Farouk responsible for Egypt’s military defeat in the 1948 Arab–Israeli War and the country's persistent socioeconomic problems, including widespread poverty, illiteracy, and underdevelopment.[49] These conditions were underscored by the stagnation of per capita gross national product (GNP), which averaged E£43 in 1954 prices between the end of World War I and the 1952 Revolution.[44]

Under Gamal Abdel Nasser, Egypt's economy saw substantial growth driven by agrarian reforms, import substitution, key nationalisation efforts like the Suez Canal Company, and major infrastructure projects, including the Helwan steel works and the Aswan High Dam. This period marked an unprecedented rise in living standards, offering Egyptians access to housing, education, healthcare, and employment.[50][51][52]

President Nasser at the inauguration of the Nasr Automotive factory in Helwan

The land reforms of 1952 aimed to weaken the old landowning class and promote industrialization, with Nasser's government supporting urban workers through labor reforms.[53] The nationalization of key industries occurred between 1957 and 1961, alongside increased public sector control.[53] While the initial economic results were positive, a crisis emerged by the mid-1960s due to the unsustainable combination of rising consumption and investment.[53]

By necessity if not by design, the revolutionary regime gave considerably greater priority to economic development than did the monarchy, and the economy has been a central government concern since then.[44] While the economy grew steadily, it sometimes exhibited sharp fluctuations.[44] Analysis of economic growth is further complicated by the difficulty in obtaining reliable statistics.[44] Growth figures are often disputed, and economists contend that growth estimates may be grossly inaccurate because of the informal economy and workers' remittances, which may contribute as much as one-fourth of GNP.[44] According to one estimate, the gross domestic product (GDP), at 1965 constant prices, grew at an annual compound rate of about 4.2 percent between 1955 and 1975.[44] This was about 1.7 times larger than the annual population growth rate of 2.5 percent in the same period.[44] The period between 1967 and 1974, the final years of Gamal Abdul Nasser's presidency and the early part of Anwar Sadat's, however, were lean years, with growth rates of only about 3.3 percent.[44] The slowdown was caused by many factors, including agricultural and industrial stagnation and the costs of the 1967 war.[44] Investments, which were a crucial factor for the preceding growth, also nose-dived and recovered only in 1975 after the dramatic 1973 increase in oil prices.[44]

Anwar Sadat's Infitah, or "Open Door Policy", introduced in 1974, marked a stark departure from Nasser's approach, shifting Egypt toward closer ties with the Western capitalist market.[53] This policy led to the emergence of a new ruling coalition, consisting of technocrats, former landowners, and private-sector entrepreneurs, further solidifying the role of market forces in Egypt's economy.[53] The changes introduced under Sadat's era effectively marked a shift towards capitalist development, contrary to the socialist trajectory some had hoped for following Nasser's reforms.[53]

Like most countries in the Middle East, Egypt partook of the oil boom and suffered the subsequent slump.[44] Available figures suggest that between 1975 and 1980 the GDP (at 1980 prices) grew at an annual rate of more than 11 percent.[44] This impressive achievement resulted, not from the contribution of manufacturing or agriculture, but from oil exports, remittances, foreign aid, and grants.[44] From the mid-1980s, GDP growth slowed as a result of the 1985-86 crash in oil prices.[44] In the two succeeding years, the GDP grew at no more than an annual rate of 2.9 percent.[44] Of concern for the future was the decline of the fixed investment ratio from around 30 percent during most of the 1975-85 decade to 22 percent in 1987.[44]

Reform era

Egypt began implementing structural adjustment reforms in the early 1990s to address a worsening macroeconomic situation marked by low growth, double-digit inflation, unsustainable fiscal and current account deficits, and heavy reliance on import restrictions to protect inefficient, state-led industries.[54] These reforms aimed to reduce the country's rentier-state characteristics by shifting economic control from the public to the private sector.[54]

Smart Village, a business district in 6th of October established in 2001 to facilitate the growth of high-tech businesses.

A major shift occurred in 2004 with the appointment of Ahmed Nazif as prime minister.[54] His cabinet introduced a new round of reforms, including the restructuring of the banking sector, increasing the private sector share, and widespread privatization of state-owned enterprises.[54] Efforts to reduce the public debt included cutting subsidies and shrinking the government workforce.[54]

In this period Egypt experienced fluctuating economic growth accompanied by shifting patterns of poverty, inequality, and middle-class formation.[55] The government undertook major policy reforms, with significant changes in income distribution, and debates over whether economic growth was inclusive or "pro-poor".[55]

Despite economic growth, poverty persisted. The proportion of Egyptians living under the national poverty line declined from 24.2% in 1991 to a low of 16.7% in 2000, before rising again to 22% in 2008.[55] Similarly, the share of the population living on less than $2 per day (PPP) fell from 28% in 1990 to 15% by 2008. Absolute extreme poverty, defined as living on less than $1.25 per day, remained relatively low at around 2% from 2000 onward.[55]

Indicator[56]	**1980**	**1990**	**2000**	**2005**	**2010**
GDP per capita at constant prices, (E£)	9,548.57	12,507.81	15,437.06	16,680.25	20,226.91
GDP per capita at current prices, (E£)	406.03	1,967.41	5,607.67	8,003.33	16,115.11
GDP per capita at current prices, (US$)	580.04	1,870.85	1,642.63	1,330.46	2,921.76
GDP (PPP) per capita, (Int$)	2,252.47	4,444.05	6,725.83	8,137.14	10,848.16

The Gini index, a measure of income inequality, remained moderate, fluctuating between 30 and 33.8 over the period. The Palma ratio, which captures the income share of the richest 10% compared to the poorest 40%, declined slightly, indicating marginal improvement in distribution.[55]

The middle class, however, exhibited a more complex trajectory. Using absolute income thresholds, the middle class appeared to constitute over 80% of the population by 2008.[55] Yet, when defined using relative or median-based thresholds, its size appeared far smaller, approximately 40% by some estimates, and even declined during periods of high economic growth.[55] This paradox reflected the vulnerability of those just above the poverty line, often labeled as “new strugglers”, who were susceptible to falling back into poverty.[55]

To stimulate investment and trade, the corporate tax rate was lowered from 40 to 20 percent, and tax collection mechanisms were strengthened. Tariff barriers were drastically reduced, and Egypt entered into preferential trade agreements with the United States, the European Union, several Arab and African neighbors, as well as neighboring states.[54] These changes contributed to an improved business climate and growing investor confidence. Between 2003 and 2008, exports of goods and services tripled, tourism surged by over 60 percent, and foreign direct investment rose by 50 percent in 2007 alone. As a result, Egypt’s external debt declined to less than 20 percent of GDP by 2009.[54]

Although the 2000s were marked by robust macroeconomic growth, the benefits were not evenly distributed. Consumption gains were concentrated among the top decile, while lower quintiles saw marginal improvements.[55] Consequently, while poverty indicators improved, public dissatisfaction remained widespread, as large segments of the population perceived limited social mobility or security.[55] The disconnect between growth and equitable distribution contributed to mounting discontent in the years leading to the 2011 revolution.[55]

2008 financial crisis

The 2008 financial crisis followed closely by the global food crisis presented Egypt with significant economic challenges, but it also prompted more integrated policy reforms. Policymakers responded quickly to mitigate the impacts of these shocks, notably adjusting monetary and fiscal policies as well as regulatory frameworks. A moderate Financial crisis took hold, partly fueled by fear of widespread panic selling, leading to declines in stock and bond markets and increases in nominal interest rates.[57]

Egypt’s population, concentrated within a narrow strip along the Nile River, primarily worked in the services, agriculture, and industrial sectors, with about one-third directly involved in farming.[58] The unemployment rate increased from 10.3% in FY2004 to 11.2% in 2005, exacerbated by the privatization efforts that led to job losses in public enterprises. Private sector employment grew at a faster pace than the public sector.[59]

In response to rising food prices, the Egyptian government, led by President Mubarak, implemented a pay rise of up to 30% for government and public sector workers in 2008. This was part of an effort to strengthen food security for low-income citizens and to balance wages with prices. The decision to double the originally proposed 15%-20% pay rise

came as widespread discontent over inflation could lead to social unrest.[60]

The consumer price index (CPI) inflation rate reached 15.8% in March 2008, with food price inflation much higher at 23.7%. These high inflation figures particularly impacted Egypt's poor and low-income citizens, who spent a large portion of their income on food. By April 2008, food inflation reached 22%, making it clear that inflation as measured by the headline CPI did not capture the struggles of the majority of the population, who were enrolled in food ration programs.[61]

Amid these economic pressures, in April 2009, Egypt was concerned about the return of 500,000 Egyptian laborers from Gulf states, which would have further complicated its economic recovery efforts.[62]

Post-revolution

Following the 2011 revolution, Egypt's economy plunged into a severe downturn, facing significant challenges in restoring growth and investor confidence. Foreign exchange reserves fell from US$36 billion in December 2010 to just US$16.3 billion by January 2012. Concerns over social unrest and financial instability led to repeated downgrades by credit rating agencies.[63] In 2016, Egypt floated its currency and initiated a reform program with a US$12 billion IMF loan to restore macroeconomic stability.[64] The sharp devaluation that followed improved Egypt's external balance but also led to inflationary pressures.[65]

Despite claims by the Central Bank of Egypt that the currency remained free-floating, reports indicated that by 2018 the central bank was actively using state-owned banks to manage the pound’s value, effectively returning to a controlled exchange rate.[66] Inflation had eased by May 2019, indicating signs of economic stabilization.[67]

Despite efforts, Egypt’s economy was hit by the global COVID-19 crisis, with real growth declining from 5.6% in FY2018/19 to 3.6% in FY2019/20, reflecting a 1.7% contraction during the April–June period of 2020.[68] The pandemic severely impacted the country's primary sources of foreign currency, particularly tourism and the oil and gas industry.[69] Although both sectors began recovering in 2022, they struggled to return to pre-pandemic revenue levels by 2023 when the outbreak of war in Ukraine further strained Egypt's economic position, as Russian and Ukrainian tourists, who form a substantial portion of Egypt’s visitor base, were largely absent.[69] Additionally, the conflict led to sharp increases in global commodity prices, particularly wheat, which Egypt imports in large quantities. These factors contributed to a broader economic crisis characterized by a resurgence of the black market due to a shortage of U.S. dollars and other hard currencies.[69]

In 2024, Egypt addressed its latest currency crisis by floating the pound once again, abandoning both implicit and tacit measures to support the currency.[25] This led to a depreciation of nearly 40% and a was followed by a record 600-basis-point interest rate hike. These measures facilitated an expanded $8 billion IMF loan, part of a broader $20 billion support package from European Union, the World Bank, Japan and the UK.[25] The currency stabilized and investor confidence improved, with Moody’s upgrading Egypt’s credit outlook and local stocks rallying. A pivotal element in this recovery was Egypt’s $35 billion investment deal with the UAE for the development of Ras El Hekma, the largest foreign investment in the country’s history.[25] Egypt also made fiscal adjustments, agreeing with the IMF to raise the tax-to-revenue ratio and accelerate the privatization of state-owned companies to strengthen public finances.[70] Both the IMF and the World Bank predicted 3.8% growth in the Egyptian economy in the fiscal year 2024/2025.[71]

Data

The following tables shows the main economic indicators in 1986–2021 (with IMF staff estimates in 2022–2027).[72]

1980s								
Year	GDP (bn US$ PPP)	GDP per capita (US$ PPP)	GDP (bn US$ nominal)	GDP per capita (US$ nominal)	GDP growth (real)	Inflation (%)	Unemployment (%)	Government debt (% of GDP)
1980	88.5	2,183.1	23.5	580.0	3.4%	20.5%	n/a	n/a
1981	▲99.0	▲2,374.7	▲25.8	▲617.7	2.2%	10.4%	n/a	n/a
1982	▲112.8	▲2,633.4	▲30.5	▲711.4	7.3%	14.9%	n/a	n/a
1983	▲127.7	▲2,900.3	▲37.3	▲846.4	8.9%	16.0%	n/a	n/a
1984	▲142.9	▲3,158.3	▲41.9	▲926.0	8.0%	17.1%	n/a	n/a
1985	▲158.3	▲3,401.8	▲48.8	▲1,049.3	7.4%	12.1%	n/a	n/a
1986	▲169.2	▲3,543.6	▲54.1	▲1,132.5	4.8%	23.9%	n/a	n/a
1987	▲180.8	▲3,705.0	▲77.4	▲1,585.2	4.3%	25.2%	n/a	n/a
1988	▲194.7	▲3,908.8	▲92.5	▲1,858.0	4.0%	15.2%	n/a	n/a
1989	▲208.3	▲4,093.2	▲115.4	▲2,266.4	3.0%	20.1%	n/a	n/a

1990s								
Year	GDP (bn US$ PPP)	GDP per capita (US$ PPP)	GDP (bn US$ nominal)	GDP per capita (US$ nominal)	GDP growth (real)	Inflation (%)	Unemployment (%)	Government debt (% of GDP)
1990	▲221.2	▲4,307.2	▼96.1	▼1,870.8	2.4%	21.2%	8.0%	n/a
1991	▲233.5	▲4,454.2	▼48.4	▼923.8	2.1%	14.7%	▲8.8%	n/a
1992	▲239.5	▲4,476.7	▼44.2	▼825.4	0.3%	21.1%	▲9.0%	n/a
1993	▲252.3	▲4,571.2	▲49.5	▲897.2	2.9%	11.0%	▲10.9%	n/a
1994	▲268.5	▲4,769.3	▲54.6	▲968.9	4.2%	9.0%	▲11.1%	n/a
1995	▲286.4	▲4,972.8	▲63.3	▲1,098.1	4.5%	9.4%	▲11.2%	n/a
1996	▲305.9	▲5,202.5	▲71.1	▲1,209.5	4.9%	7.1%	▼9.5%	n/a
1997	▲329.6	▲5,484.2	▲79.8	▲1,327.4	5.9%	6.2%	▼8.7%	n/a
1998	▲358.5	▲5,847.5	▲89.2	▲1,455.0	7.5%	5.0%	▼8.0%	73.8%
1999	▲385.7	▲6,161.6	▲95.0	▲1,518.2	6.1%	3.7%	▼7.7%	▼72.4%

2000s								
Year	GDP (bn US$ PPP)	GDP per capita (US$ PPP)	GDP (bn US$ nominal)	GDP per capita (US$ nominal)	GDP growth (real)	Inflation (%)	Unemployment (%)	Government debt (% of GDP)
2000	▲415.7	▲6,495.1	▲104.8	▲1,636.8	5.4%	2.8%	▲9.0%	▼71.7%
2001	▲440.0	▲6,738.6	▼102.3	▼1,566.2	3.5%	2.4%	▼8.8%	▲79.1%
2002	▲461.1	▲6,923.8	▼90.3	▼1,355.3	3.2%	2.3%	▲10.1%	▲85.8%
2003	▲485.2	▲7,135.9	▼85.2	▼1,252.4	3.2%	3.4%	▲11.3%	▲97.1%
2004	▲518.7	▲7,484.3	▼82.9	▼1,195.6	4.1%	8.2%	▼10.5%	▼96.5%
2005	▲558.8	▲7,904.4	▲94.1	▲1,331.4	4.5%	8.7%	▲11.5%	▲98.3%
2006	▲615.5	▲8,525.1	▲112.9	▲1,563.7	6.8%	4.3%	▼10.9%	▼85.9%
2007	▲677.0	▲9,197.8	▲137.1	▲1,862.2	7.1%	10.9%	▼9.2%	▼76.3%
2008	▲739.3	▲9,831.2	▲170.8	▲2,271.2	7.2%	11.7%	▼8.7%	▼66.8%
2009	▲778.8	▲10,127.7	▲198.3	▲2,578.9	4.7%	16.2%	▲9.4%	▲69.5%

2010s								
Year	GDP (bn US$ PPP)	GDP per capita (US$ PPP)	GDP (bn US$ nominal)	GDP per capita (US$ nominal)	GDP growth (real)	Inflation (%)	Unemployment (%)	Government debt (% of GDP)
2010	▲828.8	▲10,530.5	▲230.0	▲2,922.8	5.1%	11.7%	▼9.2%	▲69.6%
2011	▲860.9	▲10,694.4	▲247.7	▲3,077.3	1.8%	11.1%	▲10.4%	▲72.8%
2012	▲958.7	▲11,620.1	▲278.8	▲3,379.0	2.2%	8.7%	▲12.4%	▲73.8%
2013	▲992.0	▲11,726.0	▲288.0	▲3,404.3	3.3%	6.9%	▲13.0%	▲84.0%
2014	▼985.3	▼11,350.9	▲305.6	▲3,520.4	2.9%	10.1%	▲13.4%	▲85.1%
2015	▲1,064.2	▲11,957.7	▲332.1	▲3,731.2	4.4%	11.0%	▼12.9%	▲88.3%
2016	▼1,057.1	▼11,616.3	▲332.5	▼3,653.7	4.3%	10.2%	▼12.7%	▲96.8%
2017	▲1,062.3	▼11,158.3	▼236.5	▼2,484.5	4.1%	23.5%	▼12.2%	▲103.0%
2018	▲1,145.4	▲11,796.5	▲250.3	▲2,577.3	5.3%	20.9%	▼10.9%	▼92.5%
2019	▲1,230.7	▲12,444.2	▲302.3	▲3,057.0	5.6%	13.9%	▼8.6%	▼84.2%

2020s								
Year	GDP (bn US$ PPP)	GDP per capita (US$ PPP)	GDP (bn US$ nominal)	GDP per capita (US$ nominal)	GDP growth (real)	Inflation (%)	Unemployment (%)	Government debt (% of GDP)
2020	▲1,290.0	▲12,823.3	▲364.0	▲3,618.5	3.6%	5.7%	▼8.3%	▲89.6%
2021	▲1,388.3	▲13,529.9	▲402.8	▲3,925.8	3.3%	4.5%	▼7.3%	▲93.5%
2022	*▲1,562.4*	*▲14,927.5*	*▲435.6*	*▲4,162.1*	*5.9%*	*7.5%*	*▼6.9%*	*▲94.0%*
2023	*▲1,690.5*	*▲15,834.8*	*▲450.4*	*▲4,218.5*	*5.0%*	*11.0%*	*—6.9%*	*▼89.6%*
2024	*▲1,826.9*	*▲16,777.4*	*▲489.0*	*▲4,490.6*	*5.5%*	*7.4%*	*—6.9%*	*▼88.2%*
2025	*▲1,971.8*	*▲17,752.9*	*▲535.8*	*▲4,824.4*	*5.8%*	*7.4%*	*▼6.8%*	*▼86.1%*
2026	*▲2,127.9*	*▲18,782.3*	*▲584.9*	*▲5,162.9*	*5.8%*	*7.4%*	*▼6.6%*	*▼83.6%*
2027	*▲2,298.2*	*▲19,888.2*	*▲638.1*	*▲5,522.3*	*5.9%*	*7.4%*	*▼6.4%*	*▼80.7%*

Capital flows

International trade

Egypt's international trade has long been a central pillar of its economy, constituting 40% of its GDP according to the World Bank. Over the years, the country has pursued greater economic integration through a series of free trade agreements, including those with the EU-Egypt Association Agreement and the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA).[73] The association agreement with the EU, in force since 2004, established a free-trade area by eliminating tariffs on industrial goods and facilitating agricultural trade. A subsequent agreement in 2010 expanded this arrangement to processed agricultural and fisheries products. The gradual reduction of customs duties has significantly strengthened economic ties, with bilateral trade between the EU and Egypt more than doubling from €11.8 billion in 2004 to €27.9 billion in 2017.[74]

The Pan-Arab Free Trade Area (PAFTA), signed by 17 Arab League members in 1981 and implemented in 1997, aims to enhance trade among Arab states by eliminating non-tariff barriers and gradually reducing tariffs. Originally planned to achieve full tariff removal by 2007, an Arab League summit in 2002 accelerated this timeline, establishing a zero-tariff trade zone by 2005 while granting preferential treatment to the least developed member states.[74]

Egypt's participation in the AfCFTA is expected to enhance its trade with African markets, expanding beyond its traditional partners in Europe and the Middle East. As part of the Guided Trade Initiative (GTI), Egypt is working to accelerate integration, with sectors such as renewable energy, pharmaceuticals, and textiles identified as potential areas of growth. While logistical challenges exist, Egypt's established industrial base and supply chain networks may support greater regional trade and economic cooperation.[75]

Egypt also benefits from Qualified Industrial Zones (QIZs), which grant tariff-free access to U.S. markets for exports meeting predefined rules of origin. These zones offer cost advantages, exemption from non-tariff barriers, and access to Egypt's large labor pool, attracting both local and foreign investors. Initially established in Alexandria, the Suez Canal, Greater Cairo, and the Central Delta, the program has since expanded to Minya and Beni Suef.[74]

Petroleum and natural gas have historically dominated both exports and imports, reflecting the country's role as a regional energy hub. In addition to hydrocarbons, Egypt exports a diverse range of goods, including textiles, fertilizers, plastics, and agricultural products.[73]

Imports, meanwhile, are characterized by a high demand for intermediate and investment goods, reflecting the needs of the country's industrial and infrastructure sectors. Essential commodities such as iron, steel, plastics, wheat, and pharmaceuticals also constitute a substantial share of inbound trade.[73]

Egypt's exports have seen significant growth in the past years, reaching $51.1 billion in 2023.[17] The Egyptian government has set a target to increase exports to $145 billion by 2030. A new export support program, expected to launch in early 2026, will focus on boosting competitiveness by enhancing the value of Egyptian products and offering incentives for small companies and start-ups. This system, alongside the settlement of overdue dues, aims to address challenges faced by exporters, ensuring fair support distribution and fostering investment[76]

Remittances

Remittances from Egyptians working abroad constitute a key source of hard currency for the Egyptian economy. The Minister of Emigration and Expatriate Affairs reported that the number of Egyptians living abroad has increased more than fivefold since 2013, rising from 2.7 million in 2013 to 14 million in 2023[77] and according to the Central Bank of Egypt (CBE), remittances reached $23.7 billion between January and October 2024, reflecting a 45.3% increase from $16.3 billion during the same period in 2023. [78]

Remittances recorded a decline during 2022/2023, when inflows dropped to $22.1 billion from a peak of $31.9 billion in 2021/2022, figures rebounded in 2024. This was attributed to global disruptions from the COVID-19 pandemic, exchange rate volatility, and geopolitical factors, including the Russian-Ukrainian war. The March 2024 economic measures, particularly the liberalization of exchange rates and increased interest rates on Egyptian pound and dollar-denominated savings instruments, played a key role in restoring remittance inflows to the formal banking system.[78]

As a result of this recovery, Egypt has moved from sixth to fifth place globally among the top remittance-receiving countries, ranking behind India, Mexico, China, and the Philippines. The sustained rise in remittances underscores their continued importance to Egypt’s economy and highlights the impact of recent economic policies on foreign currency inflows.[78]

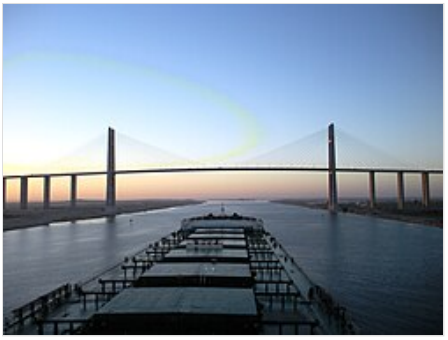
The Egyptian government considers remittances from Egyptians abroad vital to the economy and aims to sustain their growth as part of its broader economic strategy. To that end, the government has introduced various measures to attract remittances, including offering dollar savings certificates with some of the highest interest rates globally, according to the Minister of Emigration and Expatriate Affairs. These efforts aim to bolster foreign currency inflows and integrate remittances into the formal banking system.[77]

Additional incentives include customs exemptions for cars imported for personal use, requiring a foreign currency deposit refundable in Egyptian pounds after five years at the prevailing exchange rate. The government has also introduced a final exemption from compulsory conscription for draft evaders or male students abroad over the age of 18, available for a fee of $5,000 or €5,000. Furthermore, the state has promoted real estate sales in foreign currency, offering land and property to Egyptians abroad and foreign investors.[77]

According to a study by the International Organization for Migration, most remittance-receiving households use the funds for daily expenses, but 20% portion is invested in real estate, small businesses, and other economic activities.[79]

Suez Canal

The Suez Canal, a vital maritime passageway linking the Mediterranean Sea to the Red Sea, has played a crucial role in global trade since its completion in 1869. Constructed under the direction of Ferdinand de Lesseps, the canal provided a direct shipping route between Europe and Asia, significantly reducing travel time by bypassing the lengthy voyage around the Cape of Good Hope. Over the decades, the canal has undergone multiple expansions to accommodate the growing volume of global maritime trade. In 2021, more than 20,600 vessels passed through the canal, with an average of 56 ships per day.[80] To enhance its capacity, the Egyptian government launched an expansion project in 2014, widening key sections of the canal and nearly doubling its capacity from 49 to 97 ships per day.[81]



Vessel transiting through the Suez Canal

The New Suez Canal, inaugurated in 2015, introduced a parallel shipping lane and deepened sections of the original canal to accommodate larger vessels. The expansion aimed to reduce transit times from 18 to 11 hours and significantly cut waiting periods for ships. The project, costing about $8 billion,[82] was financed exclusively through domestic investment, with Egyptians contributing via bank certificates of deposit yielding 12%, later raised to 15.5%.[83] The Armed Forces Engineering Authority played a major role in the excavation and construction of the expansion, which was completed in just one year.[84]

Beyond its role as a maritime corridor, the Suez Canal has become an economic hub, with the establishment of the Suez Canal Economic Zone (SCZONE). Encompassing 461 km² across Port Said, Ismailia, and Suez, the SCZONE offers zero customs rates to attract foreign investment. Major infrastructure projects within the zone focus on the development of East Port Said and Ain Sokhna, with planned expansions to West Port Said, El-Adabiya, Arish, and El Tor.[85] This initiative is part of a broader effort to transform the canal into a global trade and logistics center, with Egypt aiming to attract $30 billion in investment within five years.[86] The canal remains a critical global trade route, setting a record annual revenue of $9.4 billion in the fiscal year ending June 2023.[87]

Exchange rate policies

In the 19th century, Egypt's currency system was based on the piastre (qirsh), subdivided into 40 para. Although formally equal to its Ottoman counterpart after the 1840 Turkish-Egyptian treaty, the Egyptian piastre was typically valued higher, leading to disparities in exchange, such as 10 Egyptian piastres equaling 11 Turkish piastres around the mid-19th century,.[88] Egypt adopted a bimetallic standard in 1834, basing its system on the Maria Theresa thaler, known as *abu taqa* in Egypt, which was valued at 20 piastres. The 1830s saw the introduction of new gold and silver coins, yet foreign coins like the British sovereign continued to circulate at unofficial rates.[88]

The 1885 currency reform led to the adoption of the gold standard, introducing the Egyptian pound (jeneih) at E£1 = 7.4375 grams of fine gold.[88][89] Pegged to the British gold sovereign, it maintained an exchange value of 97.5 piastres per pound sterling, replacing the Egyptian piastre (qirsh) as the primary currency unit.[88] This reform standardized foreign exchange rates by law and adjusted the Maria Theresa thaler to 21 piastres, while 20 piastres equaled 5 French francs.[88]

A 200 Egyptian pound note

With the outbreak of World War I, Egypt abandoned the gold standard and pegged its currency to the British pound at a fixed rate, which remained until 1962 when it shifted to the U.S. dollar.[90] In 1969, Egypt adopted a multiple exchange rate system to address two key challenges.[91] It helped mitigate the negative effects of an overvalued currency on external competitiveness while also managing the country's heavy reliance on workers' remittances.[91]

By the 1980s, external shocks, including declining oil prices and rising debt, exposed the vulnerabilities of Egypt's economy. The government attempted exchange rate liberalization in 1987, reducing multiple exchange rates from five to three, implementing a gradual devaluation, and establishing a free exchange market. However, these measures proved insufficient due to Egypt's continued dependence on external revenues from oil, the Suez Canal, and remittances, and by the early 1990s, Egypt faced mounting fiscal deficits, inflation, and a balance of payments crisis.

In response, the Economic Reform and Structural Adjustment Program was launched in 1991, backed by the IMF and World Bank. This program sought to unify exchange rates, liberalize trade, and reduce state intervention. The Egyptian pound was pegged to the U.S. dollar, supported by tight fiscal policies and high-interest rates. While this approach stabilized inflation and attracted capital inflows, it led to a gradual overvaluation of the currency, reducing competitiveness and straining foreign exchange reserves.[91]

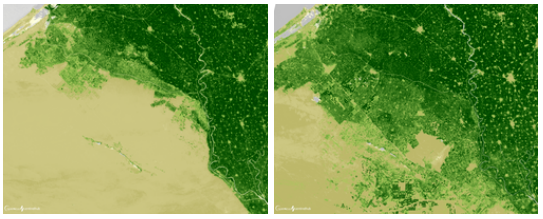
The late 1990s and early 2000s saw growing pressure on the fixed exchange rate system due to external shocks, including the 1997 Asian financial crisis and declining oil prices.[91] By 2003, Egypt adopted a managed float, allowing greater currency flexibility while still maintaining central bank interventions.[92] However, persistent trade imbalances and political instability following the 2011 revolution led to renewed currency pressures. A foreign exchange black market sprung up, and by 2016, Egypt was forced to implement a full float of the pound under an IMF-backed reform program. The sharp devaluation that followed improved Egypt's external balance but also led to inflationary pressures.[65]

By 2018, despite official claims of a free float, the Central Bank of Egypt was reportedly intervening through state-owned banks to manage the pound's value.[66] The COVID-19 pandemic and later the Russia-Ukraine war further weakened Egypt's external position, disrupting tourism, raising commodity prices, and triggering a dollar shortage that revived the black market.[66][69]

In 2024, the government floated the pound again, leading to a 40% depreciation and a 600-basis-point interest rate hike.[25] This unlocked an $8 billion IMF loan within a $20 billion international support package and helped stabilize the currency. Recovery was further supported by a $35 billion investment deal with the UAE to develop Ras El Hekma, the largest foreign investment in Egypt's history.[25]

Natural resources

Arable land



Satellite images depicting the reclamation of desert landscapes on the outskirts of the Nile Delta into agricultural land, before (left) and after (right).

Practically all Egyptian agriculture takes place in some 42,000 square kilometres (10 million acres) of fertile soil in the Nile Valley and Delta,[93] with the rest of the country being primarily desert.[94] Egypt's generally favorable climate allows for the cultivation of multiple crops annually, with most fields producing two crops per year and some vegetable areas reaching a cropping index of 300 percent.[94]

Since 2009, the growing issue of desertification has emerged as a significant challenge.[95] To address this, as well as its limited arable land and growing population, Egypt has long pursued land reclamation, with efforts dating back to the 1930s. Since then, 2.6 million feddan have been reclaimed, increasing agricultural land by 44%.[96] The latest initiative aims to reclaim 4.5 million feddan by 2027, nearly half of Egypt's existing cultivated land. The largest of these projects, the New Delta Project, spans 2.2 million feddan, the project accounts for about 25% of the country's historically reclaimed agricultural lands. The Future of Egypt, the first phase of this initiative, covers 1 million feddan and includes an industrial zone for agricultural industries.[97]

To provide water for the project, Egypt constructed the New Delta Wastewater Treatment Plant, the largest of its kind globally, as a key component of the country's strategy to expand agricultural land and enhance water security.[98] With a daily capacity of 7.5 million m^3, the plant supports irrigation efforts and mitigates pollution in Lake Mariout and the Mediterranean Sea.[98]

Additionally, the Toshka Project, initiated in the 1990s, was revived under President El-Sisi's administration. This initiative aims to reclaim 1.5 million feddan[99] in the Western Desert using water from Lake Nasser, transported via the Sheikh Zayed Canal.[100]

Acquisition and ownership of desert land in Egypt is governed by the Egyptian Desert Land Law (Law No. 143 of 1981). It defines desert land as the land two kilometers outside the border of the city.[101]

In July 2025, funding from Italy and the EU to help smallholding farmers in Egypt was agreed, totalling €24 million.[102]

Center-pivot irrigation in the Sharq El Owainat project

Water resources

"Egypt", wrote the Greek historian Herodotus 25 centuries ago, "is the gift of the Nile".[103] Due to the country's arid climate and minimal rainfall, the vast majority of Egypt's population and agricultural activity is concentrated along the Nile Valley and Nile Delta.[104] The Nile Valley in Egypt is a narrow, elongated corridor of fertile land that cuts through an otherwise arid and hyper-arid landscape. Bordered by vast desert plateaus to the east and west, the valley forms a ribbon of greenery stretching from the Sudanese border in the south to the Nile Delta in the north.[104]

The Nile river at Aswan.

To manage its limited water resources, Egypt constructed the Aswan High Dam, completed in 1970, which created Lake Nasser, one of the world's largest artificial reservoirs with a total storage capacity of 130 billion m³. The dam plays a critical role in regulating Nile flows, enabling year-round irrigation, and mitigating flood and drought cycles.[104] With a fixed annual release of 55.5 billion m³ (1.96 trillion cu ft), as stipulated by the 1959 Nile Waters Agreement between Egypt and Sudan,[94] it constitutes 97 percent of the country's renewable water resources.[103]

Facing increasing water scarcity and rising demand, Egypt has adopted treated wastewater reuse as a strategic component of its national water management policy.[105] The volume of wastewater produced in Egypt is approximately 16.4 billion m³ annually, comprising 4.4 billion m³ of municipal sewage and 12 billion m³ of agricultural drainage water.[106] As of recent estimates, Egypt operates over 400 wastewater treatment plants employing a range of technologies including activated sludge, oxidation ponds, up-flow anaerobic sludge blankets, and membrane bioreactors. Treated wastewater is primarily reused for agricultural irrigation.[105]

Rainfall in Egypt is minimal, with significant precipitation occurring only along the north coast, where annual averages range between 50 and 250 millimetres.[103] Rainfall increases eastward, reaching about 150 mm in Arish and 250 mm in Rafah. Based on average winter precipitation, the volume of rainwater falling over the northern regions of Egypt, which cover an area of approximately 200,000 km², is estimated at 5 to 10 billion m³ per year.[103] Of this, about 1.5 billion m³ contributes to surface runoff, while most of the remainder evaporates or percolates into the groundwater system.[103] In the Sinai Peninsula, surface runoff from rainfall amounts to approximately 131.67 million m³ per year, constituting 5.25% of total rainfall there. Only 200–300 million m³ are effectively harvested in regions such as Sinai, the north coast, and the Red Sea mountains.[103]

Desalination

Desalination plays a growing role in Egypt's water strategy, particularly in coastal areas lacking conventional freshwater sources. Although seawater contains high salinity levels of up to 35,000 ppm, modern desalination technologies can produce high-quality drinking water.[103] However, the process remains costly, with expenses influenced by the type of energy, technology used, and project scale. Egypt currently operates 90 desalination plants with a combined capacity of 1.3 billion m³ annually, built at a cost of $0.4 billion. Of these, 76 are fully operational, producing 850,000 m³ per day.[103]

Egypt has launched an ambitious long-term desalination strategy aimed at addressing chronic water scarcity by significantly expanding its desalination capacity. Under this national plan, the country seeks to quadruple its seawater desalination output through the construction of 21 new plants. These proposed facilities will collectively add 3.3 million m³ per day, alleviating pressure on the Nile. In a subsequent phase, Egypt plans to boost total desalination capacity by an additional 8.8 million m³ per day, with a projected investment of $8 billion.[107]

Groundwater

Egypt's groundwater resources consist of both renewable and non-renewable aquifers. Renewable groundwater is primarily drawn from two shallow reservoirs associated with the Nile River system: the Nile Valley aquifer, with reserves estimated at 200 billion m³, and the Delta aquifer, with reserves of about 400 billion m³.[103] As of 2017, an estimated 7.2 billion m³ of groundwater was extracted annually, with the Delta aquifer accounting for approximately 85 percent of this total. This extraction rate remains below the estimated safe limit of 7.5 billion m³ per year, according to the Groundwater Research Institute.[103] Groundwater quality in these regions is generally high, with salinity levels ranging from 300 to 800 parts per million in the southern Delta.[103]

Non-renewable groundwater sources are located in the deeper aquifer systems of the Eastern and Western Desert and the Sinai Peninsula.[103] The most significant among them is the Nubian Sandstone Aquifer System,[103] the world's largest known fossil water aquifer system. This vast underground reservoir, located beneath the eastern end of the Sahara desert, extends across the political boundaries of four northeastern African countries.[108] The system spans approximately 2.2 million km², with about 826,000 km² located in Egypt, nearly 40% of the total area and the largest share among the four countries, covering over 80% of the country's land surface.[109] Estimates of its total freshwater volume are as high as 500,000 billion m³.[110] Due to the depth of the aquifer and associated extraction costs, current withdrawals in Egypt are limited to approximately 0.6 billion m³ annually, primarily for irrigation in land reclamation projects. Sustainable extraction is projected to increase to 2.5–3 billion m³ per year in the future, contingent on cost-effective pumping technologies.[103]

Mineral and energy resources

Egypt possesses substantial mineral wealth, spanning both petroleum and non-petroleum resources. The country has deposits of gold, copper, iron ore, phosphate, uranium, tantalum, manganese, chromium, coal, zinc, lead, tin, and black sand minerals such as ilmenite, zircon, rutile, and magnetite[111] It also produces abundant industrial materials like granite, marble, limestone, white sand, kaolin, and feldspar.[111] These resources are primarily located in the Eastern Desert, Western Desert, Sinai Peninsula, and Alaqa Valley.[111]

An offshore platform in the Darfeel Gas Field

The Eastern Desert hosts over 1,000 ancient mining sites, including Egypt’s largest gold mine, Sukari, which began production in 2009 and has since produced over 5 million ounces of gold. Egypt's gold exports reached $1.63 billion in 2022.[111] The country’s known reserves include 3.1 billion metric tons of iron ore near Aswan, 48 million tons of tantalite in South Sinai, and 16 million tons of coal in North Sinai.[111] Uranium is found in the Eastern Desert and Sinai, with estimated reserves of 1,900 metric tons.[111] Manganese deposits at Um Bogma are estimated at 1.7 million tons, and copper reserves are about 1.6 million tons. The country also holds an estimated 700,000 tons of tin.[111]

Petroleum remains a cornerstone of Egypt's economy, accounting for approximately 25% of GDP. As of late 2023, Egypt had proven oil reserves of 3.1 billion barrels, with production around 559,000 barrels per day, and natural gas reserves of 2.1 trillion cubic meters, producing 175 million cubic meters per day.[111]

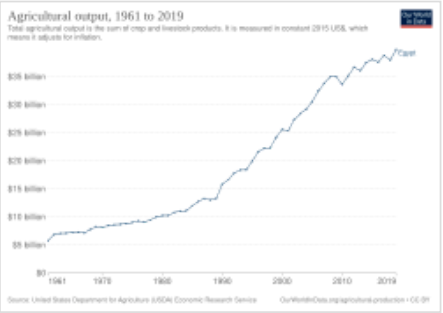
Recent legislative reforms, such as the Mineral Resources Law No. 198 of 2014 and Executive Regulations No. 108 of 2020, have modernized the investment climate.[111] These laws eliminated profit-sharing requirements, simplified licensing, and introduced tax incentives.[111] Egypt aims to increase mining’s contribution to GDP from 0.5% in 2021 to 5% by 2040, raising annual sector exports from $1.6 billion in 2020 to $10 billion.[111] The government has set a target of $1 billion in annual mining investments by 2030.[111]

Main economic sectors

Agricultural sector

Irrigation

Irrigation plays a major role in Egypt, the very livelihood of which depends upon a single river, the Nile. The most ambitious of all irrigation projects was the Aswan High Dam, completed in 1971. A report from the National Council for Production and Economic Affairs in March 1975 reflected the dam's success in regulating floodwaters and providing a reliable water supply. However, it was noted that water consumption had exceeded expectations, and measures to control this were being considered. Some fertile land was lost due to the cessation of the flow of Nile silt, and increasing salinity presented challenges. Additionally, a period of drought in the Ethiopia highlands, the source of the Nile's waters, caused the level of Lake Nasser, the dam's reservoir, to reach its lowest point in 1987.[112][113]



Development of agricultural output of Egypt in 2015 US$ since 1961

In the 1970s, despite considerable investments in land reclamation, agriculture gradually lost its place as the primary sector of the economy. Agricultural exports, which accounted for 87% of Egypt’s merchandise export value in 1960, had declined to 35% by 1974 and 11% by 2001.[114] As of the 2020s, agriculture accounts for approximately 10% of Egypt’s GDP and provides employment for 18% of the labor force.[13][4]

In 2010 Egypt's fertile area totaled about 3.6 million hectares (8.9 million acres), about one-quarter of which has been reclaimed from the desert after the construction of the Aswan High Dam.[115] The government aims to increase this number to 4.8 million hectares by 2030 through additional land reclamation.[115] Even though only 3 percent of the land is arable, it is extremely productive and can be cropped two or even three times annually. However, the reclaimed lands only add 7 percent to the total value of agricultural production. Surface irrigation is forbidden by law in reclaimed lands and is only used in the Nile Valley and the Delta, the use of pressurized irrigation and localized irrigation is compulsory in other parts of the country.[115] Most land is cropped at least twice a year, but agricultural productivity is limited by salinity which in 2011 affected 25% of irrigated agriculture to varying degrees.[115] This is mainly caused by insufficient drainage as well as seawater intrusion in aquifers as a result of over-extraction of groundwater, the latter primarily affects the Nile Delta.[115] Thanks to the installation of drainage systems a reduction in salinized areas from about 1.2 million hectares in 1972 to 900 000 hectares in 2010 was achieved.[115]

Crops

According to 2022 statistics from the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, Egypt is the world's largest producer of dates and artichokes; the second largest producer of figs and fava beans; the third largest producer of onions, eggplants, and rabbit meat; the fourth largest producer of strawberries, garlic, buffalo and goose meat as well as the fifth largest producer of buffalo milk, tomatoes and watermelon.[116]

A wheat field in Qena, Egypt

Cotton has long been a primary exported cash crop, but it is no longer vital as an export. Egypt is a substantial producer of wheat, maize, sugarcane, fruit and vegetables, fodder,[117] and rice; but also needs to import significant quantities of wheat and maize, primarily from Ukraine and Russia, despite yield increases since 1970. This is largely due to high domestic demand, driven by subsidies and a culinary preference for bread, alongside Egypt’s limited arable land and a focus on cultivating high-value export crops such as vegetables. Egypt exports rice but this can vary periodically based on government regulations, which are influenced by water and land use considerations.

Egypt's Production, Imports and Total Consumption of Wheat and Corn (Maize)
(thousand metric tons and fiscal years)

Item	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Wheat												
Production	8,400	8,500	8,250	8,300	8,100	8,100	8,450	8,450	8,770	8,900	9,000	9,800
Imports	11,650	8,400	10,150	11,300	11,925	11,181	12,407	12,354	12,811	12,149	12,000	11,000
Total consumption	18,600	18,700	18,500	19,100	19,200	19,400	19,800	20,100	20,300	20,600	20,500	20,600
Maize												
Production	5,500	5,800	5,800	5,960	6,000	6,000	6,400	6,800	6,400	6,400	7,440	7,440
Imports	7,154	5,059	8,791	7,839	8,722	8,773	9,464	9,367	10,432	9,633	9,200	9,200
Total consumption	11,700	12,000	13,200	13,900	14,850	15,100	15,900	16,200	16,900	16,400	16,400	16,400
Sources: [118] [119] [120] [121] [122] [123]												

Land is worked intensively and yields are high. Increasingly, modern techniques are applied to producing fruits, vegetables and flowers, in addition to cotton, for export. Further improvement is possible. The most common traditional farms occupy 0.40 hectares (1 acre) each, typically in a canal-irrigated area along the banks of the Nile. Many small farmers also own cows, water buffalos, and chickens. Between 1953 and 1971, some farms were collectivised, especially in Upper Egypt and parts of the Nile Delta.

Flower production.

Cacti, particularly cactus pears, are widely cultivated across Egypt, including Sinai, and extend into neighboring countries. Introduced during the Columbian Exchange, they have become a significant crop in the region.[124]

The government exercises a strong degree of control over agriculture, usually through financial incentives and export bans, not only to ensure the best use of irrigation water but also to confine the planting of water intensive crops like cotton in favor of food grains. However, the government's ability to achieve this objective is limited by crop rotational constraints.[125]

Land ownership

The agrarian reform law of 1952 provided that no one might hold more than 200 feddans, that is, 84 hectares (210 acres) (1 Egyptian feddan=0.42 hectares=1.038 acres), for farming, and that each landholder must either farm the land himself or rent it under specified conditions. Up to 100 additional feddans might be held if the owner had children, and additional land had to be sold to the government. In 1961, the upper limit of landholding was reduced to 100 feddans, and no person was allowed to lease more than 50 feddans. Compensation to the former owners was in bonds bearing a low rate of interest, redeemable within 40 years. A law enacted in 1969 reduced landholdings by one person to 50 feddans.[126]

Farmland in the Egyptian countryside

By the mid-1980s, 90% of all land titles were for holdings of less than five feddans (2.1 hectares (5.2 acres)), and about 300,000 families, or 8% of the rural population, had received land under the agrarian reform program. According to a 1990 agricultural census, there were some three million small land holdings, almost 96% of which were under five feddans. As these small landholdings restricted the ability of farmers to use modern machinery and agricultural

techniques that improve and take advantage of economies of scale, there have since the late 1980s been many reforms attempting to deregulate agriculture by liberalizing input and output prices and eliminating crop area controls. As a result, the gap between world and domestic prices for Egyptian agricultural commodities has been closed.[127]

Climate change

Even without the impacts of climate change, Egypt's arid climate makes it vulnerable for water scarcity and food scarcity. Most of Egypt does not receive much rain, thus all of its agricultural production is around the Nile River. The population of Egypt is increasing, therefore the country will require more food and water.[128][129][130] Agriculture is important to the Egyptian economy, making up 11.3% of the GDP and providing 28% of jobs.[131] However, climate change is creating challenges for the agricultural sector. One concern is decreasing crop production. Due to heat stress, water stress, and salinity, food crop yields are projected to decline by 10% by 2050.[132] The crops with the largest yield declines are expected to be maize, oilseeds, sugarcrops and fruits and vegetables.

Egypt is dependent on global markets for wheat imports and food security.[132] Egypt consumes 20.5 million tonnes of wheat a year, half of which is produced domestically with the remaining half supplied from imports.[133] However, wheat yields in Egypt are expected to reduce nearly 20% by 2060.[134] Other impacts of climate change on agriculture include reduced water availability, increased pests and diseases, and a shorter growing period in some places.[135] Prices for imported food will increase as a result of climate change due to global declines in crop production.[132] Hotter temperatures and increased drought will also impact livestock, including cows and chickens. Heat and water stress reduces milk yield and quality, egg yield, and animals' reproductive capacity. Given increases in the human populations and decreases in milk production, models predict that milk availability will decrease by 40 kg per person by 2064.[136] Together, these climate change impacts on agriculture will threaten food security in Egypt.

Industrial sector

Chemical products

The chemical industry in Egypt is one of the country's largest, comprising seven key subsectors: plastics, rubber, paper, detergents, paints, miscellaneous chemicals, fertilizers, and glass. The petrochemical segment alone accounts for approximately 12% of Egypt's industrial output.[137]

An industrial complex near Edfu.

The sector is forecast to generate $9 billion in exports by the end of 2024, with growth supported by abundant raw materials and foreign investments. The government aims to enhance competitiveness by focusing on infrastructure, technological advancements, and export incentives. The sector also benefits from Egypt's participation in regional trade agreements, helping to further expand its export market and strengthen its global position.[138]

Abu Qir Fertilizers Company is one of Egypt and the MENA region's largest nitrogen fertilizer producers, accounting for nearly 50% of Egypt's nitrogen fertilizer output. Established in 1976, its first ammonia-urea production facility is located in Abu Qir, 20 kilometers east of Alexandria. Egypt Basic Industries Corporation (EBIC) is also a leading ammonia producer in the country.[139]

Consumer electronics and home appliances

Egypt's consumer electronics and home appliance industry has witnessed significant expansion, driven by government initiatives and foreign investments. The "Egypt Makes Electronics" initiative, launched in 2015, aims to localize manufacturing, reduce imports, and boost exports. It has attracted major players like Samsung, Hisense, Beko, and Haier, who have established production facilities in Egypt, benefiting from tax incentives and golden licenses. The country's strategic location, competitive labor costs, and growing consumer market have positioned it as a key regional manufacturing and export hub.[140][141]

The home appliance industry is seeing increased localization, with some manufacturers already sourcing 70% of components domestically. The mobile phone segment has also expanded, with brands like Vivo, Infinix, and Oppo setting up local factories. However, challenges persist, particularly in accessing raw materials, navigating bureaucratic hurdles, and securing timely export subsidies. The easing of foreign currency restrictions and policy adjustments have alleviated some constraints, fostering a more favorable investment climate.[140][141] Electrolux, which entered the Egyptian market by acquiring local Olympic Group, also aims to expand its market share and boost exports, capitalizing on the strong local presence of its brands, particularly Zanussi and Olympic Electric.[142]

Despite challenges, Egypt's electronics and home appliance sector continues to grow, with international investors increasingly viewing it as a reliable manufacturing base. Rising local production has reduced import dependency while creating jobs and strengthening supply chains. If current trends continue, with improvements in raw material availability and regulatory efficiency, Egypt could solidify its role as a leading producer and exporter in the region's electronics and home appliance market.[140][141]

Gold

Gold mining in Egypt's Red Sea region has developed into a fast-growing industry, driven by vast untapped reserves. In an effort to establish a modern mining sector, the Egyptian government launched its first international bid round, awarding mineral concessions to attract investment. This marked a significant shift in policy, encouraging private sector participation in a historically state-dominated industry. Among the early participants were AngloGold Ashanti and Alexander Nubia International, both of which reported promising technical results in their exploration efforts.[143][144]

Sukari gold mine

The Sukari mine, located in the Sukari Hills near Marsa Alam, became Egypt's first large-scale modern gold production facility. The government granted a concession to Centamin in 2005, awarding the company an exploitation lease covering 160 square kilometers. Sukari quickly became Egypt's largest gold mining operation, representing a turning point in the country's efforts to commercialize its gold resources.[145]

Egypt has launched a sweeping modernization drive to raise the mining sector's GDP contribution to 5–6% by 2030. Reforms include transforming the Mineral Resources Authority into an economic entity, removing bureaucratic hurdles, and introducing new investment models for gold extraction, all intended to attract investment and align regulations with global standards.[146] As part of this effort, a Digital Mining Platform is set to launch in early 2025 to boost transparency, streamline licensing, and enhance investor engagement through digital tools.[147]

These reforms have driven a surge in gold exports, which nearly doubled to $2.17 billion in the first nine months of 2024, up from $1.11 billion during the same period in 2023. With continued government backing, Egypt aims to rank among the world's top 10 gold exporters by 2027.[148]

Iron and steel

Egypt's iron and steel industry has played a crucial role in the nation's economic development, with a history dating back to 1936. Over the decades, the sector has expanded through state-owned enterprises and private firms, becoming a key driver of industrial growth and employment. As of 2024, Egypt is Africa's leading steel producer, third largest in the Middle East and 19th globally, with an output of 10.7 million metric tons of crude steel produced in 2024.[149] EZDK is the largest steel company in Egypt and the Middle East, today part of Ezz Industries. It owns four steel plants in Alexandria, Sadat, Suez and 10th of Ramadan. It was ranked 77th on the list of the world's largest steel companies by the World Steel Association in 2020, with a production of 4.57 million tons.[150]

In 2023 exports of reinforced steel surged more than threefold, reaching 1.54 million tons compared to 523,000 tons in the previous year. At the same time, crude steel production grew by 6% to 10.4 million tons, supported by increased exports, particularly in hot-rolled coil.[151]

Domestic consumption of steel products has steadily increased, reflecting the industry's importance to infrastructure and construction projects. However, the sector faces challenges, including outdated production technologies and competition from lower-cost imports, particularly from Turkey, China, and Ukraine. The government has implemented policies to support the industry, including trade protections and incentives to attract investment. Forecasts indicate a steady growth rate of 1.5% annually over the next decade, driven by Egypt's expanding infrastructure projects and strategic geographic position as a trade hub.[152]

Motor vehicles

El Nasr Automotive Manufacturing Company, Egypt's state-owned automaker, was established in 1960 in Helwan and began operations in 1962, producing vehicles under license from brands such as Zastava Automobili, Mercedes-Benz Group, Kia, and Peugeot.[153] The company resumed production in 2024 after a 15-year hiatus, beginning with electric buses in partnership with China's Yutong.[154] It markets three bus models under its own brand: Nasr Green,[155] Nasr Sky,[156] and Nasr Star.[157] The company plans to reintroduce passenger cars by the end of 2025, targeting an annual output of 20,000 vehicles.[154]

The fully electric MCV C127 EV, made in Egypt for the German market

Other major manufacturers include Arab American Vehicles, Egy-Tech Engineering, Ghabbour Group, WAMCO, and MCV, which has represented Mercedes-Benz since 1994 and operates a factory in El Salheya employing around 2,500 workers.[158]

Egypt's 2024–2030 automotive strategy aims to boost annual production to 400,000–500,000 vehicles, with 25% for export, targeting $4 billion in revenue. Local firms like Ezz Elarab Group and El Sewedy Electric have partnered with Indonesia's Proton Holdings, while Nissan Motor Egypt plans to add new models. Chinese automaker Exeed, in partnership with Egyptian-German Automotive, has also begun local assembly in 6th of October City.[159]

A key component of the strategy is launching electric vehicle production in 2025 through partnerships with international firms. This includes integrating EVs into public transport via e-taxis and initiating trial production at Nasr Auto. Broader plans involve establishing automotive hubs and enhancing local component manufacturing to support both domestic and export growth.[159]

Personal care and pharmaceutical products

Established in 1939 with the founding of the Misr Company for Pharmaceutical Industries, Egypt's pharmaceutical sector is one of the nation's oldest strategic industries. Over the past two decades, the market has expanded fivefold, and as the healthcare system modernizes, the industry is expected to continue its growth trajectory, attracting multinational pharmaceutical companies focused on emerging markets.[160] The number of pharmaceutical factories increased from 130 in 2015 to 170 in 2023, marking a 30.8% rise. Similarly, production lines expanded by 40%, growing from 500 in 2015 to 700 in 2022. In this period Egypt went from being the world's 47th largest pharmaceutical producer in 2015 to 29th in 2023.[161]

Egypt has the largest pharmaceutical market in Africa, with an estimated value of $56.6 billion. The country's pharmaceutical exports were valued at approximately $400 million in 2023. However, the domestic pharmaceutical industry remains highly dependent on imported inputs, with around 90% of raw materials sourced from abroad. While the sector exhibits a relatively high level of complexity, opportunities exist to increase local manufacturing capacity and reduce import reliance.[162]

The Egyptian beauty and personal care market has experienced significant growth, driven in part by a series of currency devaluations that have increased consumer preference for locally produced goods.[163] In 2025, the sector is expected to generate $7.6 billion in revenue,[164] with a projected compound annual growth rate of approximately 8.1% between 2024 and 2030.[165]

Textiles and clothing

Egyptian women working at a factory making medical clothes

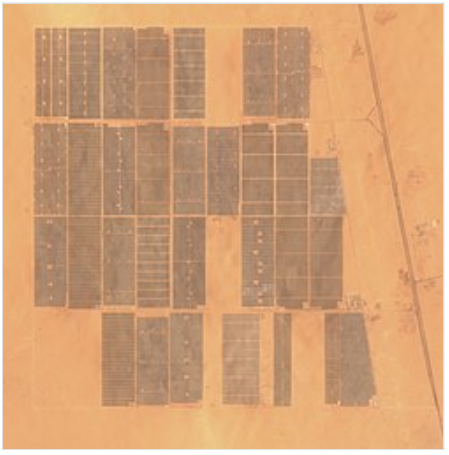
The textile industry is a key component of Egypt's economy, accounting for approximately 12% of the country's export earnings and 3.4% of its gross national product as of 2023. It employs around 2.5 million people and includes one of the largest and most productive cotton and textile clusters in Africa. The entire production process, from cotton cultivation to finished garments, occurs domestically, with cotton comprising roughly 75% of natural fibre use. Egypt is internationally known for its extra-long staple cotton varieties, particularly Giza cotton, derived from Gossypium barbadense.[166]

Egypt's apparel market was valued at approximately $17.04 billion in 2023, with women's apparel comprising the largest segment at $7.58 billion. The market is projected to grow at an annual rate of 5.53% through 2028. Between 2014 and 2021, 6,740 textile companies were established, with issued capital totaling EGP 10.5 billion.[167] Over 450 of these were established between 2016 and 2019 with foreign investment.[166] The public sector accounts for 50% of spinning, 60% of knitting, and 60% of weaving, while the private sector dominates garment manufacturing with a 90% share.[167]

Mahalla El Kobra serves as the center of Egypt's textile production and is home to the state-owned Misr Spinning and Weaving Company, which owns one of the largest spinning and weaving factories in the world. The sector includes approximately 6,500 textile-only factories among 85,000 establishments. Between 2011 and 2020, Egypt experienced a compound annual growth rate of 12% in textile exports. Major export destinations include the European Union, Asia, the Middle East, and Africa, with products such as denim, cotton yarns, and non-woven fabrics.[166]

Energy sector

Electricity


Benban Solar Park

Egypt suffered blackouts during the summer of 2014 that lasted for up to six hours per day. A rapid series of reforms cut energy subsidies, and Egypt quickly developed the Zohr gas field in the Mediterranean, which was discovered in 2015. The country now has an oversupply of electricity and aims to source 20% of its electricity from renewables by 2022 and 55% by 2050.[28]

As part of its renewable energy strategy, Egypt has undertaken large-scale projects like the Benban Solar Park and the Gabal El Zeit wind farm. Benban, located near Aswan, has a total capacity of 1650 MW and generates about 3.8 TWh annually, making it the fourth-largest solar power plant globally. Additionally, the Gabal El Zeit wind farm, costing €340 million, spans 100 square kilometers with 300 turbines, generating 580 MW of electricity.[168][169][170]

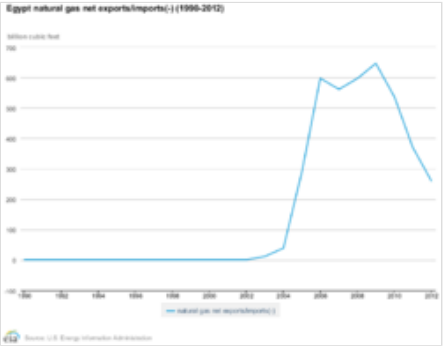
Egypt and Cyprus are considering implementing the proposed EuroAfrica Interconnector project.[171][172][173][174][175] This consists of laying a 2 GW HVDC undersea power cable between them and between Cyprus and Greece, thus connecting Egypt to the greater European power grid.[173] The interconnector will make Egypt an electricity hub between Europe and Africa. The president of Egypt and the prime minister of Cyprus met in Nicosia on 21 November 2017 and showed their full support for the EuroAfrica Interconnector pointing out its importance for energy security of the three countries.[176][177][178][179]

On 29 October 2007, Egypt's president, Hosni Mubarak gave the go-ahead for building several nuclear power plants, but this failed to take off under his leadership. On November 19, 2015 Egypt and Russia signed an initial agreement, under which Russia will build and finance Egypt's first nuclear power plant. In December 2017 preliminary contracts for the construction of four VVER-1200 units were signed in the presence of Egyptian President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi and

Russian President Vladimir Putin.[180] The permit for unit 1 was issued by the Egyptian Nuclear and Radiological Regulatory Authority (ENRRA) in June 2022.[181] First safety-related concrete was poured in July 2022.[182] In October 2022, ENRRA gave construction approval for unit 2,[183] whose construction started on 19 November.[184]

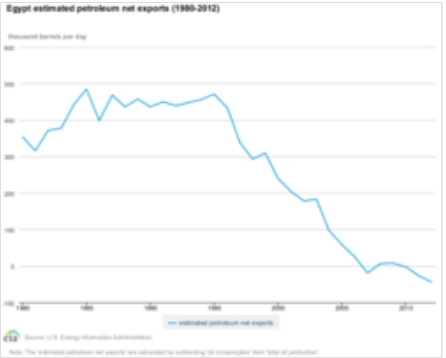
Hydrocarbons

The Egyptian government has long prioritized expanding the petrochemical industry and increasing natural gas exports. By 2009, 38% of locally produced natural gas was allocated for export. However, declining crude oil production, peaking at 941,000 bbl/d (149,600 m^3/d) in 1993 before falling to 630,000 bbl/d (100,000 m^3/d) by 2008, led Egypt to shift focus toward natural gas. By 2008, gas production had reached 48.3 billion cubic meters, though rising domestic consumption turned Egypt into a net oil importer by 2008–2009.[186]



Egypt's net natural gas exports.[185]

In 2014, Egypt prioritized domestic gas consumption over exports, significantly reducing international supply. The country also signed a 15-year agreement with Israel to import 7 billion cubic meters of gas annually from the Leviathan field.[187] A year later, BP announced a $12 billion investment in Egypt's natural gas sector, primarily in the West Nile Delta project, which now produces nearly 1 billion cubic feet per day (bcf/d). BP also developed the Atoll field (300 million standard cubic feet per day) and the North Damietta concession, with production from the Qattameya discovery starting in 2020.[188][189]



Egypt's oil consumption is overtaking oil production.

The Zohr gas field, discovered by Eni in 2015, remains the Mediterranean's largest natural gas find, with estimated reserves of 30 trillion cubic feet. Production began in December 2017, reaching 2.7 bcf/d by August 2019.[190] However, recent technical challenges have reduced Zohr's output, leading to domestic supply constraints and increased reliance on imports. Egypt has secured agreements with Cyprus to import gas from the Cronos and Aphrodite fields, processing it in Idku and Damietta for LNG exports to Europe. Efforts to revitalize Zohr include new drilling plans to increase production by 220 million cubic feet per day.[191]

Construction sector

Egypt's construction industry, valued at USD 55.04 billion in 2025, is projected to reach USD 82.34 billion by 2030, with an annual growth rate of 8.4%. Contributing around 14% to GDP, the sector benefits from state-led infrastructure investment and growing foreign interest, particularly from Gulf sovereign funds. Real estate remains a key driver, with USD 20 billion invested in Cairo in 2022, largely in housing. The introduction of real estate trading on the Egyptian Exchange and the launch of a dedicated real estate fund have further diversified the market.[192]

Major projects such as the Cairo Metro Lines 3 and 4, the two-line Cairo Monorail, and the high-speed rail network are reshaping national infrastructure. These initiatives are complemented by large-scale energy projects like the El Dabaa Nuclear Power Plant and various renewable energy developments.[192]

Construction of the central business district in Egypt's new capital in 2021

Flagship developments include the proposed new capital of Egypt, launched in 2015, and New Alamein, a north coast city spanning 48,000 feddans, both part of Egypt's fourth-generation cities.[193][194]

Residential construction leads the market with a 37% share in 2024, supported by a young population and pro-housing policies. Industrial construction, meanwhile, is the fastest-growing segment, expected to grow 12% annually through 2029, driven by foreign investment and specialized industrial zones.[192]

Leading firms include Hassan Allam Construction, Dorra Holding, Arab Contractors, Orascom Construction, and SIAC Industrial Construction & Engineering.[192]

Services sector

Banking

The Central Bank of Egypt is the national reserve bank, regulating the financial market and the Egyptian pound. Egypt's banking sector has undergone major reforms since the 1990s, resulting in a liberalized and modernized system aligned with international standards. By late 2024, total bank assets reached approximately 21 trillion Egyptian pounds (USD 420 billion), a significant rise from EGP 633 billion (USD 101 billion) in 2004.[195]

Egypt's banking system dates back to 1856, evolving through privatization, mergers, and foreign bank exits, such as Société Générale's 2012 sale of National Société Générale Bank to QNB Al Ahli.[196] Despite private sector growth, state-owned commercial banks remain dominant.[197]

Financial inclusion has expanded, with 74.8% of Egyptians aged 15 and above using financial accounts, reaching 52 million users by 2024.[198] Usage spans banks, Egypt Post, mobile wallets like Vodafone Cash and MobiCash, and prepaid cards like Meeza. Women's financial inclusion grew 295% since 2016 thanks to policies and initiatives aimed at empowering women financially, reaching 68.8%, while youth participation rose 65% from 2020 to 2024, hitting 53.1%.[199]

The fintech sector has expanded 5.5-fold since 2020, with 177 startups ranking Egypt 10th among emerging markets. Growth, driven by digital payments, lending platforms, and B2B marketplaces, is bolstered by financial inclusion policies.[199] With over 60% of the population under 30, youth adoption is high, though cybersecurity risks, regulatory gaps, and digital literacy disparities remain challenges.[199]

Finance

The origins of Egypt's stock exchange date back to 1883 with the establishment of the first futures market in Alexandria. In 1902, the Brokers' Syndicate was formed, introducing the first set of regulations governing stock market activities.[200]

Today, the Egyptian Exchange (EGX) comprises the Cairo and Alexandria stock exchanges, operating under a unified trading, clearing, and settlement system. It serves as the primary platform for equities, bonds, and financial instruments in Egypt. The exchange has undergone multiple phases of reform, including privatization initiatives, regulatory adjustments, and structural enhancements to improve market liquidity and attract foreign investment.[201]

Egypt's stock market has experienced fluctuations due to global economic conditions, foreign capital flows, and domestic policy changes. Periods of IPO activity and privatization efforts have contributed to market expansion, while external shocks, such as global financial downturns and geopolitical events, have periodically impacted performance. Government-led reforms have included revisions to listing rules, the introduction of sectoral indices, and measures to increase market depth, such as the establishment of a treasury bonds index and approval for special purpose acquisition companies. Plans for further market development include the launch of EGYCOMEX, the Egyptian Commodities Exchange, and the introduction of derivatives trading, both aimed at diversifying financial instruments and strengthening Egypt's position as a regional financial hub.[201]

ICT and communications

The headquarter of Telecom Egypt

The liberalization of Egypt's telecommunications sector began in 1998, gradually expanding private sector involvement in mobile telephony and internet services. In 2004, the Information Technology Industry Development Agency (ITIDA) was established under Law 15 to drive Egypt's digital transformation, implement e-signature legislation, and promote an export-oriented IT sector.[202] Deregulation followed in 2006 after Egypt joined the World Trade Organization's Information Technology Agreement in 2003, opening the market to competition and foreign investment.[203] By 2007, Egypt had 10 million fixed lines, 31 million mobile subscribers, and 8.1 million internet users.[204]

The ICT sector has since become a major driver of economic growth, expanding by 15.2% in FY 2022/2023 and contributing 5.1% to Egypt's GDP, up from 4.4% in 2019/2020. Investments in the sector reached $4.2 billion in 2022/2023, a 20% increase from the previous year.[205] The telecommunications market operates under a unified license system, with key players including Telecom Egypt, Vodafone, Orange, Etisalat Egypt, and Ericsson.[206]

Looking ahead, Egypt's ICT market is projected to grow from $23.6 billion in 2025 to $53.1 billion by 2030, at a compound annual growth rate of 17.61%.[207] The government's Digital Egypt initiative aims to transform the country into a digitally-driven society by expanding infrastructure, fostering innovation, and modernizing public services. As part of this strategy, and the broader Egypt Vision 2030, the government has integrated 33,000 institutions into a secured digital network and enhanced online services, improving transparency and efficiency.[208]

Between 2019 and 2022, mobile internet subscriptions surged by 77.9%, from 39 million to 69.4 million, with total mobile subscriptions reaching 106.2 million by December 2023.[209] Internet penetration reached 72.2% in early 2024, with 82 million users.[210] The country also leads Africa in internet speed rankings and is set to generate $3.5 billion in smartphone revenue by 2025, growing at an annual rate of 6.11% until 2029.[211][212]

Transport

The Cairo Metro.

Transport in Egypt centers on Cairo and follows settlement along the Nile. The Nile River (1,600 km (990 mi)) and major canals of equal length serve local transport.[213]

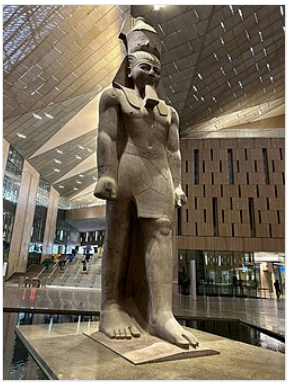
Since 2014, the National Roads Project has driven major upgrades to Egypt's road network, adding 6,300 km of new roads and upgrading 8,400 km at a combined cost of 265 billion Egyptian pounds. This expanded main roads by 29.8% to 30,500 km and improved Egypt's ranking in the Road Quality Index from 118th globally in 2015 to 18th in 2024.[214]

Egypt's 4,800 kilometres (3,000 mi) railway network is operated by Egyptian National Railways. In 2021, the National Authority for Tunnels signed a $4.5 billion contract with Siemens Mobility, Orascom Construction, and Arab Contractors to build a 660 km (410 mi) electrified high-speed rail line linking Ain Sokhna, Mersa Matruh, and Alexandria. Dubbed the "Green Line" or "Suez Canal on rails,"[215][216] it will carry both freight and passengers using Velaro high-speed trains, Desiro regional sets, and Vectron freight locomotives. Two more lines were announced in 2022, connecting Greater Cairo to Aswan and Luxor to Hurghada and Safaga.[217][216][218]

Egypt Air and private carriers such as Nile Air and Air Cairo operate frequent domestic flights from Cairo International Airport to major tourist destinations.

The Suez Canal, managed by the Suez Canal Authority, is a vital global shipping route linking the Mediterranean and Red Seas. Egypt's main ports include Alexandria, Port Said, and Damietta on the Mediterranean, and Suez, Ain Sokhna, and Safaga on the Red Sea.[219][220]

Tourism


Grand Egyptian Museum

Tourism in Egypt grew significantly after 1975 when the government eased visa restrictions and focused on tourism infrastructure. By 1981, tourist arrivals had risen to 1.8 million, reaching 14.7 million in 2010. However, the COVID-19 pandemic caused a sharp decline, with revenues dropping to $4 billion in 2020 and arrivals falling to 3.5 million. In February 2022, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) noted that Egypt's tourism sector was the biggest loser from the pandemic.[221][222][223][224]

Egypt's government has initiated several projects in the tourism sector, including the Grand Egyptian Museum. Once completed, it will be the largest museum in the world. This museum aims to showcase Egypt's rich archaeological heritage, strengthening the country's position as a global tourist destination.[225][226]

In 2024, Egypt achieved a record 15.7 million tourists, surpassing the previous year's 14.9 million. This achievement, attributed to government efforts to enhance security and tourism support, marks a strong recovery from the pandemic's impact. After the drastic decline in 2020, tourism has rebounded, with revenues reaching $14.1 billion, up from previous years.[227]

The country's tourism strategy includes plans to attract 30 million tourists by 2028, with continued improvements to infrastructure and the tourist experience. Egypt's top markets in 2024 included Germany, Russia, and Saudi Arabia.[227]

Emerging sectors

Defence and security products

RAAD 200, a multiple rocket launcher produced in Egypt on display at EDEX 2023

Egypt's defence industry is among the oldest and most extensive in the Arab world, comprising a network of state-owned enterprises and a growing private sector. It produces small arms, munitions, drones, armored vehicles, and naval vessels, often through local manufacturing or co-production agreements.[228][229]

To bolster self-sufficiency and exports, Egypt launched a $479 million weapons manufacturing strategy in 2020 to modernize 84 production lines. It has leveraged partnerships and events like the Egypt Defence Expo to showcase capabilities and position itself as a regional hub.[230]

The Ministry of Military Production oversees firms such as Abu Zaabal Specialized Industries, Abu Zaabal Engineering Industries, and the Armoured Production and Repair Factory, which produces systems like the M1A1 Abrams, K9A1EGY, RAAD 200, and Sinai 200. It also oversees Thales & Benha Electronics S.A.E., a joint venture with Thales Group for co-producing communications and electronic systems.[231]

The Arab Organization for Industrialization (AOI) oversees companies like Kader, Sakr, and Arab American Vehicles, as well as joint ventures such as Arab British Dynamics. It operates aerospace and engine factories in Helwan, producing the Alpha Jet, K-8E, and pursuing licensed production of the KAI T-50 Golden Eagle.[232] The Alexandria Shipyard builds corvettes, frigates, and patrol vessels, and has partnered with Naval Group and ThyssenKrupp Marine Systems to produce the Gowind 2500 and Meko A200 classes locally.[233][234][235]

Private sector players include Robotics Engineering Systems, specializing in drones, smart munitions, and guided missiles,[236] and Amstone, which develops advanced unmanned aerial and naval systems.[237]

Semiconductors and electronic chips

In 2024, Egypt launched a national policy to localize semiconductor and electronic chip manufacturing, identifying the sector as a strategic priority for economic growth and technological self-reliance.[238] The initiative provides incentives such as tax breaks, land access, and technical support to promote investment in semiconductors, embedded systems, and circuit design.[239] It forms part of the broader *Egypt Makes Electronics* program, a presidential strategy launched in 2015 to advance high-value electronics design and manufacturing and generate employment in labor-intensive production.[239]

To coordinate implementation, the government established the National Council for the Localization of Semiconductor Technology, chaired by the Prime Minister and comprising representatives from key ministries.[238] The council is responsible for setting strategy, tracking investments, addressing regulatory barriers, and coordinating with both domestic and international stakeholders.[238] A major component of the policy is the integration of local mineral resources into supply chains for microelectronics.[238] It also includes training initiatives, incentives for investors, and a national roadmap to guide integration into global value chains, supported by an international consultant.[240]

In parallel, Egypt partnered with China's Tsinghua Unigroup in 2024 to launch a $300 million investment fund focused on semiconductors and artificial intelligence, with over 80% of the capital contributed by the Chinese side in collaboration with Egyptian partners.[241]

As of 2025, Egypt hosts 23 semiconductor startups, with several notable companies emerging in the sector.[242] These include Si-Ware Systems, which specializes in ASICs and MEMS; Avelabs, focused on embedded software for the automotive industry; SilMinds, a developer of hardware acceleration solutions for high-performance computing; Wasiela, which designs communication IP cores and digital media systems; and NeoSpectra, known for MEMS-based spectral sensors.[242] InfiniLink, an Egyptian semiconductor startup founded in 2023, secured $10 million in seed funding in 2025, one of the largest deep-tech seed rounds in the MENA region.[243] The company specializes in next-generation, energy-efficient optical transceiver chiplets designed for telecom, AI data centers, and IoT infrastructure.[243][244]

Largest companies

In 2024, one Egyptian company was listed in the Forbes Global 2000 list, an annual ranking of the top 2000 public companies in the world by Forbes magazine.

World rank	Company	Industry	Revenue (billion $)	Profits (billion $)	Assets (billion $)	Market value (billion $)
1663	Commercial International Bank	Banking	4.67	0.967	20.61	4.83

Forbes Middle East also published a separate 2024 ranking of the top 50 listed companies in Egypt, highlighting other major publicly traded firms that did not feature on the global list but remain key players in Egypt’s economy. Following Commercial International Bank in the local ranking were QNB Al Ahli and Elsewedy Electric, each with a market capitalization of $1.4 billion. They were followed by Telecom Egypt (4th), Orascom Construction (5th), and Talaat Mostafa Group (6th). Rounding out the top ten were Egypt Kuwait Holding, Faisal Islamic Bank of Egypt, Abu Qir Fertilizers, and Misr Fertilizers Production Company.[245]

The banking and financial services sector dominated with 16 entries, contributing $8.4 billion in sales and holding $58.5 billion in assets. The real estate and construction sector followed with nine firms, and the industrial sector accounted for seven.[245]

Investment climate

Historically, private equity has played a limited role in business financing in Egypt. However, the government has undertaken several initiatives to improve the investment climate and attract foreign direct investment (FDI). The Investment Law of 2017 was introduced to streamline procedures and investor incentives, and was followed by a new company law and bankruptcy law in 2018 and a customs law in 2020, all aimed at creating a more efficient business environment.[246] Alongside these legal amendments, efforts to simplify company registration and encourage foreign participation have contributed to making Egypt one of the leading FDI destinations in Africa between 2016 and 2020.[247][246]

To further enhance its economic attractiveness, Egypt has implemented fiscal reforms such as reducing corporate tax rates and cutting trade tariffs, aimed at increasing foreign investment and economic growth.[248] At the same time, large-scale infrastructure projects, including transportation modernization, new urban communities, and the Suez Canal's expansion, have been pursued to reduce logistical costs, enhance trade efficiency, and provide improved facilities for investors.[249]

As part of the reforms, Egypt introduced "golden licenses", a single-approval mechanism that allows investors to acquire land and begin operations without requiring multiple approvals from various government bodies. The General Authority for Investment and Free Zones (GAFI) oversees the program, which aims to reduce bureaucracy and attract FDI. As of March 2024, 26 golden licenses had been granted.[248] Additionally, in July 2023, President El-Sisi ratified Law No. 159 of 2023, which eliminated exemptions for state-owned enterprises, ensuring equal regulatory treatment for all investors.[248]

To further encourage foreign capital inflows, the government has also introduced a citizenship-by-investment program, offering residency and citizenship in exchange for financial contributions.[250]

Despite these efforts, challenges persist. Issues like corruption and the need for improved enforcement of regulatory frameworks continue to impact investor confidence. In 2024, Egypt scored 30 out of 100 on Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index, ranking 130th out of 180 countries.[251]

Regional data

Data shown are for the year 2021 in nominal numbers.

Governorate	GDP (billion EGP)[252]	GDP (billion US$)
Cairo	1,876.650	119.543
Giza	770.071	49.054
Alexandria	565.876	36.046
Qalyubiyya	339.316	21.614
Sharqia	302.065	19.242
Dakahlia	294.016	18.729
Beheira	288.857	18.400
Port Said	190.154	12.113
Gharbia	173.763	11.069
Monufia	157.267	10.018
Kafr El Sheikh	151.053	9.622
Faiyum	133.504	8.504
Minya	130.976	8.343
Asyut	126.143	8.035
Suez	119.129	7.589
Matrouh	115.552	7.361
Damietta	110.340	7.029
Sohag	107.757	6.864
Ismailia	91.127	5.805
Beni Suef	87.194	5.554
Qena	80.395	5.121
Aswan	76.265	4.858
Red Sea	75.872	4.833
South Sinai	58.386	3.719
North Sinai	48.932	3.117
Luxor	46.634	2.971
New Valley	16.963	1.081
Egypt	**6,627.028**	**422.142**

Challenges

Poverty

Egypt has struggled to implement effective policies to address poverty. Past efforts to alleviate economic burdens often benefited wealthier segments of society. For example, food, electricity, and petroleum subsidies have historically disproportionately aided the non-poor.[253]

Street vendors in Cairo.

Egypt's fertility rate has dropped from 6.6 children per woman in the 1960s to 3.2 children per woman in 2021, though it remains high relative to global standards. The population increased from 44 million in 1981 to over 106 million today. Overpopulation remains one of the biggest challenges to confronting poverty.[254][255]

The country's reliance on international loans, such as from the IMF, has sometimes resulted in increased hardship for the population. In August 2022, Egypt sought another loan amid rising prices, triggering criticism of economic policies that primarily benefited elites.[256]

Cairo slums.

The poverty rate in Egypt increased from 19 percent in 2005 to 21 percent in 2009, as reported by then Minister of Economic Development, Othman Mohamed Othman.[257] The national poverty rate stood at 24.3% in 2010, rising to approximately 30% by 2015. Additionally, a 2019 World Bank report indicated that 60% of Egypt's population was either poor or vulnerable.[258]

As of 2020, Egypt's population stood at 102 million, with 33% under the age of 14. Approximately 30% of the population lived below the poverty line.[259][260] By 2021, this figure had declined slightly to 29.7% of the population.[261]

Role of the military

The Egyptian armed forces have wielded substantial influence over Egypt's economy. Military-run companies play a pivotal role across various industries, contributing significantly to public spending on housing and infrastructure, including activities such as cement and food production, as well as infrastructure development like roads and bridges. According to a study by the Carnegie Middle East Centre, the Egyptian army has control over about 25% of public spending allocated to housing and infrastructure.[262]

Despite Egypt's commitment to reducing the military's economic impact per its agreement with the International Monetary Fund (IMF), recent developments indicate an opposing trend. The National Service Products Organization (NSPO), a firm under military ownership, is currently constructing new factories for the production of fertilizers, irrigation machines, and veterinary vaccines. The government discussed selling stakes in military-run companies Safi and Wataniya for two years. Despite claims of receiving offers, there are visible asset transfers, like the rebranding of Wataniya franchises into ChillOut stations.[262] The army's expanding economic influence, from petrol stations to media, has stifled competition, hindered private investment and contributing to slower growth, higher prices, and limited opportunities for ordinary Egyptians.[263]

In 2022, responding to international calls for economic reform, Egypt introduced the State Ownership Policy Document in collaboration with the IMF. The document outlines Egypt's strategy to reduce state and military involvement in the economy, withdrawing entirely from certain industries within three years while maintaining or expanding a presence in strategic sectors. It also seeks to increase private sector participation by clearly defining the state's economic role, enhancing governance of state-owned enterprises according to OECD standards, and promoting competitive neutrality.[264] By the final quarter of 2024, these reforms had led private investment to exceed public investment for the second consecutive quarter, representing over half of total investments. During this period, private investments increased by 35.4% year-on-year, whereas public investments declined by 25.7%,[265] marking a significant departure from Egypt's recent history of public investment dominance.

Opportunity cost of conflict

A report[266] by Strategic Foresight Group has calculated the opportunity cost of conflict for Egypt since 1991 is almost US $800 billion. In other words, had there been peace since 1991, an average Egyptian citizen would be earning over US $3,000 a year instead of US $1,700.

See also

- The Sovereign Fund of Egypt
- Egypt

- Emerging markets
- List of companies of Egypt
- Next Eleven
- Qualifying Industrial Zone
- Waste Management in Egypt
- United Nations Economic Commission for: Africa & Western Asia

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External links

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